

Engineering a Scalable Dynamic Pricing and Dispatch Ecosystem for the Indian Ride-Hailing Market

The architectural requirements for a ride-hailing application aiming to serve between 1 and 10 million users in the Indian market are uniquely demanding. This scale necessitates a distributed system that can handle massive concurrency, real-time telemetry, and volatile environmental factors such as monsoon weather patterns, erratic urban traffic, and localized demand surges during festivals. By employing a high-performance technology stack centered around the Bun runtime for core microservices, Python/FastAPI for specialized artificial intelligence workloads, and a hybrid database strategy including PostgreSQL, ScyllaDB, Redis, and HE3, the platform can achieve the sub-second latency required for a competitive user experience. This comprehensive technical report details the strategies for horizontal scaling, the implementation of dynamic pricing through machine learning, and the robust event-driven workflows facilitated by Kafka and gRPC.

Distributed Microservices and the High-Performance Runtime Environment

The selection of the Bun runtime as the primary execution environment for the majority of the application's microservices is a strategic decision motivated by its exceptional I/O performance and low memory footprint. Bun is engineered using the Zig programming language and utilizes the JavaScriptCore engine, which provides significant advantages over traditional V8-based runtimes like Node.js in terms of startup speed and requests-per-second (RPS) throughput. In the context of a ride-hailing platform where services must scale rapidly to accommodate peak demand hours—typically morning and evening commutes in Indian metropolitan areas—Bun's near-native execution performance ensures that the "API Gateway" and "Rider/Driver Management" services do not become bottlenecks.

While Bun handles the high-throughput business logic, a dedicated Python service using the FastAPI framework is integrated specifically for artificial intelligence and machine learning tasks. Python's mature ecosystem, including libraries such as TensorFlow, PyTorch, and Scikit-learn, makes it the ideal choice for training and serving the complex models required for demand forecasting and dynamic surge calculation. FastAPI provides an asynchronous bridge, allowing the AI service to interact seamlessly with the rest of the microservice mesh via gRPC, maintaining non-blocking behavior even during intensive inference cycles.

Performance Metric	Bun Runtime	Node.js (Express)	FastAPI (Python)
Mean Response Time	~157ms	~815ms	~220ms (Async)
Throughput (Req/Sec)	~6,400+	~667	~5,000+
Stability under Load	100% (0 failed)	25% (High failure)	High
TypeScript Support	Native	Requires transpilation	Via Type Hints
Best Application	Real-time APIs	Legacy Systems	ML & Data Science

Service Communication via gRPC and Protocol Buffers

To ensure efficient communication between these disparate services, the architecture utilizes gRPC, a high-performance Remote Procedure Call (RPC) framework. Unlike RESTful APIs that utilize human-readable JSON over HTTP/1.1, gRPC employs binary serialization through Protocol Buffers (protobufs) and operates over HTTP/2. This transition results in significantly reduced payload sizes and enables features such as multiplexing and bidirectional streaming, which are critical for services requiring persistent connections, such as the "Dispatch Engine" and "Live Tracking Service". By defining strict service contracts in .proto files, the platform ensures type safety across both the Bun (TypeScript) and Python environments, reducing runtime errors and simplifying the development of complex features like real-time fare negotiation or multi-stop routing.

Event-Driven Backbone: Kafka for Global Telemetry and Reliability

Apache Kafka serves as the central nervous system of the application, decoupling data producers from consumers to enable an asynchronous, event-driven architecture. For a system scaling to 10 million users, the volume of GPS telemetry alone can reach billions of events daily. Kafka's ability to partition topics by geographic region or user ID allows for massive horizontal scaling, ensuring that the platform remains responsive even during extreme surges in activity.

Multi-Tiered Event Ingestion and Processing

The event pipeline is structured into multiple layers to balance the need for raw data retention with the requirements of real-time business logic. The "Raw Ingestion Layer" (e.g., events.raw) captures every telemetry ping from driver and rider applications, including potentially malformed or redundant data. A secondary "Standardized Stream" consumes these raw events, performing validation, deduplication, and schema enforcement. This layer is where data is enriched with contextual metadata, such as the current H3 geospatial index of the coordinates, before being passed to critical business services.

For financially sensitive operations, such as ride completion and payment settlement, Kafka's Exactly-Once Semantics (EOS) are strictly enforced. This prevents the catastrophic scenario of double-charging a user or miscalculating driver earnings due to network retries or consumer crashes. The use of transactional producers ensures that the database update and the event publication to the next Kafka topic occur atomically, maintaining consistent state across the entire distributed system.

Kafka Topic Tier	Primary Purpose	Consistency Requirement	Partitioning Strategy
events.raw	Ingestion of all telemetry	At-least-once	Event Type
events.cleaned	Validated and enriched data	At-least-once	Entity ID (Driver/Rider)
trip.lifecycle	Dispatch and matching	At-least-once	Trip UUID
billing.critical	Payments and settlements	Exactly-once	Payment ID

Kafka Topic Tier	Primary Purpose	Consistency Requirement	Partitioning Strategy
analytics.fanout	BI and ML training	At-most-once	Region / City

The Hybrid Database Strategy: ACID, High-Throughput, and Encryption

Scaling to 10 million users requires a nuanced approach to data persistence, as no single database can optimize for every ride-hailing use case. The platform employs a hybrid strategy that leverages the unique strengths of PostgreSQL, ScyllaDB, Redis, and HE3DB.

PostgreSQL and transactional consistency

PostgreSQL acts as the primary system of record for user profiles, driver authentication, and complex relational entities. Given the complexity of the Indian urban landscape, PostgreSQL's PostGIS and H3 extensions are utilized to manage spatial boundaries and zone-level analytics. For high-availability and cloud-native management, the application utilizes the CloudNativePG operator on Kubernetes, which automates primary/standby failover and integrated backup streaming to S3-compatible storage. As the write volume increases, the platform can implement horizontal sharding via extensions like Citus or migrate specific high-traffic domains to dedicated PostgreSQL instances.

ScyllaDB for high-throughput persistent telemetry

While Redis is ideal for real-time location caching, it often struggles with the CPU overhead of heavy aggregation and long-term history storage. ScyllaDB, a C++-based wide-column store, is employed for its shard-per-core architecture, which allows it to handle millions of operations per second with single-digit millisecond latency. In a ride-hailing context, ScyllaDB is the optimal store for trip history, archival GPS trajectories, and persistent metadata aggregations that inform long-term pricing trends. Major platforms such as Grab have demonstrated that migrating high-throughput workloads from Redis to ScyllaDB can reduce infrastructure costs and eliminate performance spikes during peak hours.

Redis for real-time coordination and geospatial indexing

Redis remains the cornerstone for volatile, high-frequency operations. The platform utilizes Redis Geospatial indices for rapid proximity searches, identifying available drivers within a specific radius of a ride request using geohash prefix matching. Furthermore, Redis is used to implement distributed locking via the SETNX command, ensuring that a ride offer can only be accepted by a single driver, thereby preventing race conditions in high-density areas. Surge pricing multipliers for every H3 cell are also cached in Redis with a Time-To-Live (TTL) of only a few seconds, ensuring that the pricing engine can retrieve localized rates with sub-millisecond latency.

HE3DB for encrypted and elastic data management

To address the increasing requirements for data privacy and security-sensitive computations, the platform integrates HE3DB. HE3DB is an efficient, encrypted database that utilizes Fully Homomorphic Encryption (FHE) to allow for computations on encrypted data without decrypting it first. This is particularly valuable for handling sensitive user attributes used in individualized

pricing or fraud detection, ensuring that personally identifiable information (PII) is never exposed in the clear during the analytical process. HE3DB's elasticity and arithmetic-logic optimization provide a 20x to 1370x speedup compared to traditional FHE implementations, making it viable for production-grade ride-hailing analytics.

Dynamic Pricing Engine: Variables and AI Modeling

Dynamic pricing is the core mechanism that balances rider demand with driver supply in real-time. In India, pricing must account for extreme variability across different vehicle categories, ranging from low-cost bikes and autos to premium prime cabs. The pricing engine uses a sophisticated formula to determine the final fare:

where:

- Base is the starting fare (e.g., ₹12 for bikes, ₹50 for prime cabs).
- $Dist_{Total}$ and $Time_{Total}$ are estimated via the mapping provider.
- μ_{surge} is the dynamic multiplier determined by the AI service.
- δ_{offer} represents the impact of active promotions or discounts.

Key Pricing Variables and Triggers

The dynamic pricing engine monitors a wide range of external and internal signals to adjust the surge multiplier (μ_{surge}):

1. **Demand-Supply Ratio:** The primary driver of surge. Calculated per H3 cell index. For example, a ratio of 2:1 (two riders searching for every one driver) might trigger a 1.2x surge, while a 10:1 ratio could push it to 2.0x or higher.
2. **Environmental Factors (Weather):** In Indian cities, monsoon rain can cause a 30-50% spike in demand while simultaneously reducing supply as bike and auto drivers seek shelter. The AI service consumes weather API data to proactively increase surge multipliers when precipitation is detected.
3. **Traffic Congestion:** Real-time traffic metadata from Google or Ola Maps is used to adjust the $Rate_{Time}$ component. Heavy traffic increases the opportunity cost for drivers, necessitating higher fares to maintain supply.
4. **Temporal and Event-Based Context:** Morning peak hours (e.g., 8:00 AM to 11:00 AM) and night surcharges (+10-18% base increase) are baseline adjustments. The system also tracks localized events such as cricket matches, festivals (e.g., Diwali), or public transit strikes that drastically alter normal demand patterns.

Implementing AI for Demand Forecasting and Surge

The Python-based AI service employs several machine learning models to optimize the pricing strategy:

- **Random Forest and Gradient Boosting (GBDT):** These ensemble methods are used as a baseline for predicting fare amounts based on historical ride data, providing high interpretability and handling non-linear relationships between features like distance and time of day.
- **Long Short-Term Memory (LSTM) Networks:** Given that ride-hailing data is inherently temporal, LSTMs or ConvLSTMs are used to forecast short-term demand (10-30 minute intervals) by analyzing sequences of past ride requests across the city.

- **BiLSTM with Attention:** To improve accuracy in high-volatility environments, bidirectional LSTMs with attention mechanisms can identify which historical factors (e.g., a similar rainy Thursday three weeks ago) are most relevant to current pricing.
- **Reinforcement Learning (Future Outlook):** Advanced systems may implement reinforcement learning to explore pricing strategies that maximize long-term driver retention and rider lifetime value rather than just immediate transaction revenue.

Model Type	Primary Task	Data Features	Output
Random Forest	Surge Multiplier	Demand/Supply Ratio, Time, Weather	μ_{surge}
LSTM / ConvLSTM	Demand Heatmap	Historical Request Counts, Location	Predicted Demand
DeepETA (Deep Learning)	Trip Duration	Real-time Traffic, Historical Routes	Estimated Time
Anomaly Detection	Fraud/Safety	GPS Jumps, Deviations from Route	Fraud Score

Data Schema for Pricing, Offers, and Analytics

A robust database schema is essential for tracking granular pricing details and enabling advanced analytics such as user savings reports. The schema must distinguish between the transactional data needed for the ride and the analytical data needed for business intelligence.

Core Transactional Pricing Entities

The "Trips" and "Payment" tables serve as the primary source of truth for every completed ride.

- **Trips Table:** Includes trip_uuid, rider_uuid, driver_uuid, vehicle_type, status (Requested, Completed, Cancelled), base_fare, distance_fare, time_fare, and surge_multiplier.
- **Payment Table:** Tracks payment_uuid, amount_paid, method (UPI, Card, Cash), tax_amount (GST), platform_fee (commission), and third_party_fee (e.g., payment gateway charges).
- **Driver Earnings Table:** Specifically records the driver's net take-home pay, calculated as Subtotal - Fees - Taxes + Bonus.

Offers, Promos, and User Savings Analytics

To calculate and display "Total Amount Saved," the system requires dedicated tables for promotion management.

- **PromoCodes Table:** Stores promo_id, code_string, discount_type (Percentage/Flat), max_discount, and expiry_date.
- **RideDiscounts Table:** An associative table linking a trip_uuid to a promo_id, storing the actual discount_amount applied to that specific ride.
- **UserSavings Dashboard (Query Logic):** To provide the "how much saved till now" field, a background service aggregates the discount_amount from the RideDiscounts table for a specific user_uuid. For performance at scale, this sum is often pre-aggregated in a UserAccount table and updated via a Kafka consumer after every trip completion event.

Analytical Fields for Dynamic Pricing Optimization

For the data science team to refine pricing models, the schema must capture the "Willingness To Pay" (WTP) and market competitiveness.

- **Offer Logs:** Capture events where a rider was shown a price but did not book (conversion funnel).
- **Competitor Benchmarking:** Tables storing scraped or third-party data on competitor fares and ETAs in the same geographic zones.
- **Elasticity Metadata:** Fields tracking the user's device type (iPhone users may exhibit different price sensitivity), battery level, and historical acceptance of surge fares.

Abstract Mapping Layer: Switching Between Google and Ola Maps

The application implements an abstract interface for mapping services to allow runtime switching between Google Maps and Ola Maps. Ola Maps is frequently preferred for the Indian market due to its "Crafted for India" focus, which includes more accurate landmarks, regional nuances, and a significantly lower pricing model (up to 70% cheaper than Google in some categories).

Implementation using the Strategy Pattern

In the Bun/TypeScript environment, the application utilizes the Strategy Design Pattern to encapsulate mapping logic. This decouples the business logic (e.g., "Request a Route") from the specific API implementation (e.g., "Call Google Directions API").

```
// Abstract Strategy for Mapping
interface IMapProvider {
  getRoute(origin: LatLng, destination: LatLng): Promise<RouteResult>;
  getETA(origin: LatLng, destination: LatLng): Promise<number>;
  getDistance(origin: LatLng, destination: LatLng): Promise<number>;
}

// Concrete Google Maps Implementation
class GoogleMapsProvider implements IMapProvider {
  private client = new Client({}); // From
  @googlemaps/google-maps-services-js
  async getRoute(origin, destination) { /*... */ }
}

// Concrete Ola Maps Implementation
class OlaMapsProvider implements IMapProvider {
  // Uses Ola Maps REST APIs with Bearer token authentication
  async getRoute(origin, destination) { /*... */ }
}
```

By using a MapStrategyManager, the platform can dynamically select the provider based on several factors:

- **Cost Efficiency:** Using Ola Maps as the default for high-volume routing requests in Tier-1 cities to minimize API fees.

- **Accuracy Fallback:** If Ola Maps lacks data for a specific newly-developed suburban area, the system can transparently fallback to Google Maps for that specific request.
- **Regional Specialization:** Using Ola Maps for routes requiring localized landmarks ("the shop next to the temple") which are better represented in their India-centric dataset.

Scaling Strategies and Precautions for 10 Million Users

Reaching a scale of 10 million users requires transitioning from basic cloud deployment to a resilient, distributed infrastructure that prioritizes high availability and fault tolerance.

Horizontal Scaling and Statelessness

The golden rule for scaling to millions of users is the absolute statelessness of application servers. All session data must reside in external stores like Redis, allowing the Bun-based microservices to be scaled horizontally behind load balancers. Load balancers utilize algorithms such as "Least Connections" or "IP Hash" to distribute the influx of rider requests and driver location streams across multiple server pools.

Concurrency Precautions and Race Condition Mitigation

In a high-density market like India, multiple drivers often attempt to accept the same ride request simultaneously. To prevent double-booking, the system implements distributed locking in the Dispatch Service.

1. **Ride Request Publication:** When a rider requests a trip, a unique token is generated and pushed to nearby drivers via Socket.io.
2. **Atomic Lock Acquisition:** The first driver app to send an "Accept" signal triggers a Redis SETNX operation on the trip token.
3. **Conflict Resolution:** If the SETNX returns 1, the driver is assigned. If it returns 0 (the lock is already held), the system instantly notifies other drivers that the ride has already been taken.

Regional Isolation and Fault Domains

To mitigate the risk of a nationwide outage, the architecture is partitioned into independent regional fault domains. Each major Indian city or cluster (e.g., Delhi-NCR, Bangalore, Mumbai) operates its own instance of the WebSocket gateway and Redis geo-index. This "Cellular Architecture" ensures that a failure in one region's infrastructure does not cascade to the entire platform. Kafka MirrorMaker 2 is used to replicate critical global data (user accounts, billing) across regional Kafka clusters for disaster recovery.

Managing Driver Telemetry and Network Volatility

In India, mobile network conditions can be highly erratic. To reduce the load on the backend while maintaining accurate tracking, the platform implements several precautions :

- **Downsampling:** Drivers only stream GPS deltas (changes in position) rather than constant pings. Updates are typically throttled to once every 5 seconds during an active

trip and 15 seconds when idle.

- **Dead Reckoning:** The client-side application interpolates the vehicle's position between server updates based on its last known velocity and heading, providing a smooth animation for the rider without requiring high-frequency server communication.
- **Ingestion Cleaning:** A dedicated Kafka consumer validates GPS coordinates against a road network (using Ola or Google Roads API) to snap noisy points to the nearest road, preventing "jumping car" visual artifacts.

Operational Precautions for Pricing Fairness and Compliance

Aggressive dynamic pricing can lead to user alienation and regulatory challenges. In India, ride-hailing platforms are increasingly under scrutiny for price transparency and algorithmic bias.

Surge Caps and Transparency

The pricing engine must implement "Surge Caps" to prevent fares from reaching socially or legally unacceptable levels during emergencies (e.g., severe flooding or public transit strikes). Transparency is maintained by providing the rider with a clear "Fare Breakdown" before they book, explaining that the price includes a surge component due to "Extreme Traffic" or "High Demand".

Algorithmic Fairness and Driver Retention

Pricing models must be balanced to ensure they do not systematically disadvantage certain segments of the population or the driver pool. For instance, drivers in low-demand areas must be incentivized with "Boosts" or "Heat Map Bonuses" to maintain geographic coverage, even if immediate ride demand is low. This prevents "deadheading"—where drivers travel long distances without a passenger—and improves the overall allocational efficiency of the platform.

Conclusions

Building a ride-hailing platform for 10 million users in India is a complex engineering endeavor that requires a deep integration of real-time telemetry, predictive AI, and highly available distributed systems. The selection of the Bun runtime provides the necessary performance foundation, while Python/FastAPI offers the flexibility for sophisticated dynamic pricing models. By leveraging Kafka as the event-driven backbone and a hybrid database strategy (PostgreSQL, ScyllaDB, Redis, and HE3), the application can maintain transactional integrity while processing millions of concurrent location updates.

The implementation of an abstract mapping layer using the strategy pattern ensures that the platform can optimize for cost and regional accuracy by switching between Ola and Google Maps. Simultaneously, precautions such as distributed locking, regional isolation, and surge capping are vital for maintaining system stability and user trust. As the platform scales, the focus must remain on the synergy between algorithmic precision and human-centric fairness, ensuring that dynamic pricing serves to balance the ecosystem rather than purely extracting maximum value. This architectural blueprint provides the technical roadmap necessary to navigate the

unique challenges of the Indian urban mobility market at massive scale.

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